

good she is. The other two losses came against Han Yue (2-9) and Akane Yamaguchi (15-17).

"An is a very comprehensive player. Every opponent has some skills. An is very talented and strong. Every time I play her, I learn something from her," Yufei says.

Comprehensive is what sums up An's game. Although she has a lot of variation, she will not wow you with brilliance the way Tzu Ying would. She does not show the emotion that Marin would. She does not hit with the most power; her hardest smash in the tournament clocked 372 kmph, only the sixth fastest of the tournament. For contrast, P. V. Sindhu smashed a couple of clicks short of 400 kmph at her peak. An is just extremely precise, and opponents can rarely count on too much margin for error.

What nearly every player also acknowledges is that she brings a physicality that is setting the benchmark for where the women's game is right now.

"I think her style is very strong. It's very physical. It's just such a high pace that she plays at. If you don't have that baseline physicality, you're not going to beat her. And that's where she's kind of put that standard," says Li.

Even as her opponents are trying to catch up, An is pulling further away.

"I think she's working on more variety in her game. So, I think she's added the power aspect along with the cardio. So it's interesting to see her development too, from when she first started to now," says Li.

Still improving

As if she were not scary enough already, the Korean says she is looking to get even better. In an interview with the BWF, An said she was looking for perfection. That means even restricting opponents to single digits is not satisfactory.

"I think the moment when I win 21-0 is the perfect moment, and I want to do that," An said.

"I am still very far from my best. I am very young, and I still have many things to show. It's my aim to reach

the level of perfection. I am trying daily to get there. It seems like it will take a long time. It might not even happen," she says.

And so, An continues to strive. But even though her target is perfection, this does not mean that she goes in expecting to beat every opponent across the net. "I feel pressure (that I win so much). I don't think that it makes it easy for me. I have to get better and do my best on the day. It is not difficult to get motivation. I always want to win," she told reporters after her semifinal win.

One area where An has improved, which was visible when she flexed a bicep after beating Ratchanok, is the muscle mass she has gained in the past year. "I work out three times a week. I've been weightlifting so that I am not left behind because of my power. That is my goal for this year. I have worked a lot. It has helped in developing my strength and making me more confident and powerful," she told reporters.

In improving her physicality, An is probably trying to iron out one of the few challenges she has faced: the limits of her own body.

Full-court movement and tenacious retrieving define An's defensive approach. This, and the fact that her dominance on court means she plays many more matches than nearly every other player (she competed in 77 official matches last year), leads to higher physical exhaustion and a greater risk of injury. The Korean has dealt with chronic knee problems since the Asian Games in 2023. Last year, she withdrew midway through her semifinal match at the China Open.

"When I come to these tournaments, I play one, two, maybe three matches if I've played amazingly, but she's playing five

every single time. So, I think it's a line between being light enough to be agile and strong enough to be robust and not get injured. And she's had her injuries, but she's pretty strong in her joints and her muscles," says Gilmour.

As long as she is on court, though, opponents are aware they are in for a hard time.

This does not mean that they are not trying.

Wang has had her chances in the last two encounters between the two. She lost the second game of the Malaysia Open final earlier this year 22-24, while pushing An to a third game at the World Tour Finals.

Yufei, whom Wang beat in the semifinals in Delhi, says her Chinese teammate's best chance will be to find a way to believe.

"She has had two close matches but lost both of them. When you play against An, you need to have a lot of confidence," she says.

In the final, you could see Wang trying something she had not done before. She tried to increase the pace at which she was playing. She increased her offensive output and even played the double-footed jump smash more often than she usually does.

It was an effort that did not pay off in New Delhi.

"She is very consistent, strong and fast. She is very comprehensive, good in every aspect and has a lot of skills. She is one of the toughest opponents I have faced, an extraordinary player," the two-time Asian champion Wang admitted after her loss.

For now, it is back to the drawing board for Wang as she continues to pursue an enigma.

For An Se-young, though, the only chase it seems is perfection.

« An Se-young has opened 2026 with two titles; the most she conceded at the Indian Open was 17 points in a game »